

Counseling and Academic Advising

This is also a part of eStudent Services (online). On the same topic as Richard and Leon presented. The concept of "Peer Counselors": it's also possible, with the full eStudent Services package, for students, faculty, and advisors to be interconnected with each other. It's about sharing information, resources, experience, and learning. In terms of technology, it's a business function and the role the user plays. It's the same thing as passing a business function called Counseling from a counselor to a student. It's role-playing that is described by a business function.

You have made some valid points, and I agree with you. However, I'm advocating for a collaborative solution that enables the sharing of information and processes. A student is connected to both a teacher and an advisor, who share a methodology for helping the student. Picture, if you will, a student who needs help. He requests a help service request, say advising. Both an advisor and a teacher are interconnected in the informational exchange about a student to determine the kind of service. Student information is being evaluated in the call analysis phase to determine a point of service. The action is determined by the best-fit scenario for the student.

In any decision-making, it is perception and point of view that lead to a decision and an action. In helping a student, it's our best interpretation of best-fit advising needs and situation. The difference with face-to-face is that a person's expression and our reading of the situation depend on certain circumstances.

Now, the argument may be that advising provided is non-applicable. This is very possible. So, is the system fail to perform its function? Well, I mentioned earlier that both faculty and advisor are exchanging information about a student. The student's part in this collaboration is decision-making and action. If the information is not applicable, it feeds back into the initial phase (requesting a service). The system continues in this analysis cycle until an advising need is met.

Is this eAdvising fit for all students' needs? No, there will be certain circumstances where advising needs can't be determined. In such a situation, the student can request physical contact with an advisor. Ideally, eAdvising requests service from a physical person and provides the student with an appointment. The prospective advisor is well aware of the student's situation and needs. Face-to-face contact may help here.

The benefit is information sharing that enables tracking, advising, statistics, research, etc. Since the idea is still in its infancy, there is no physical data to show the outcome. But it's about efficiency and improving processes across various pillars. The model may not fit all institutional types. I can see that it fits well with Alliant, Phoenix University, distance learners, and other large universities.

Just remember from our class discussion: the number of students per counselor is disproportionate. Taking a pie and dividing it into 4 slices, roughly 25% have no advising; 25% have some needs; 25% are disabled students; 25% are minority students. Maybe the first 50% may find it helpful, while the other 50% may have problems using it or are not available, but it helps 50% of the student population. I'm seeing ongoing feedback on learning and experimenting, and those processes may improve over time. As we all know, knowledge can be acquired through experience and learning. This is no different.

This morning, I had a phone problem, so I called the SBC hotline. The voice recognition system prompted me to various scenarios (billing, payment, ...) and finally, I spoke to a live representative. At the end of our conversation, I still had the same issue. The excuse is "No, it's not in my department, ... you need to call back with this number ..." I'm still having a problem with phone service. You know what happened next.

What I'm proposing is dual-process advice. All are in a single information-sharing.